Now he was feigning to be helpful. ‘Don’t worry. You just give us any name. Give us a Muslim name.’

There, I thought, he was letting me in to the layers of his imaginary spy story. When I stood my ground, the officer said if I don’t go by their story line I would be handed over to some other team which would take me to Pathankot in Punjab. There, he threatened, I would be shot dead and the media will be told that I was killed in an encounter while trying to escape from the investigating team.

I asked for water.

‘Unless you confess you are not going to get a drop of water,’ he said.

‘You third rate criminal,’ now shouted the subordinate officer, ‘you want water?’

My tormentors have taken out third-degree measures, I realised. I had a choice: To stand by my innocence or yield to their designs. I was helpless, I may even be shot dead in Pathankot. But how can I tell myself, leave alone this bunch of goons who masqueraded as IB officials, that I could do anything against my mother land? After all, it was Vikram Sarabhai’s dreams and convictions that I followed to serve my country. I cannot let down Sarabhai, my father, my gurus and myself. I resolved to die if that was the way out of this mess.

The subordinate was holding a glass of water a couple of feet away from me, as if to lure me into parroting their cock-and-bull story. I got up from my chair.

‘I don’t want water. I don’t want to sit any longer. I will stand here, without food or water, till you agree that I have done nothing wrong.’

Now the interrogators appeared to have been tired of making me tell things that went with their story line; so they decided to give a gist of their story so that I merely agreed. Having decided not to question or correct them, I listened as they gave me an outline of their creation:

The six accused in the ISRO spy case – Mariam Rasheeda, Fauziyya Hassan, D Chandrasekhar, D Sasikumaran, S Nambi Narayanan and SK Sharma – worked as a group and transferred rocket technology to Pakistan. Raman Srivastava was the leader of the gang that met on 24 January 1994